

Infinite Monkey Theorem

“iherioenrqw4m5SLK’o3]-020,” a rhesus macaque slapped on the rusty keys. Like most of the others, this unit was nonfunctional, and half of the hammers were rusted together. The ribbon was worn and the text was faded. He grunted several times, and hobbled down the dim and decaying aisle. Intermittent hooting whoops from the other insomniacs pierced the oppressive darkness, echoing though the six-mile hallway. Shattered skylights exposed shafts of moonbeams, with hanging ivy casting sinister shadows. His matted gray beard hung in clumps as he gazed despondently toward the broken ceiling. A roiling knot perched not twenty feet above him, twisting with impatience. The macaque squinted; his eyes were worn from age and disuse, seeing only the silhouetted gyrations overhead. Rustling leaves in the wind, perhaps. His tensed shoulders decompressed and the hardened scowl faded from his pink brow.

As Number 12’s guard relaxed, he ceased his furtive glances and occupied himself with futilely attempting to cup a large, juicy silverfish with his hands. Anticipating a snack, each time he peeked between his grubby fine and found them empty, the prey scuttling away in desperate and directionless hairpin turns. The old monkey eventually lost interest, and the silverfish retreated beneath a rotting sheaf of paper. His obfuscated observer waited for a corresponding decrease in limb temperature – less oxygen-enriched blood flowing to the muscles. Within seconds the coil unwound from the creaky scaffold and an eight-foot Burmese python crashed upon the feeble monkey, whose head soon disappeared into the jaws. Endless folds of cold muscle dampened the macaque’s guttural alarm squeal, and silence again devoured the Type Ward. Houdini the escaped serpent lazed contentedly in the lightless and dusty corner, pressing the sizable lump of dead primate further down his digestive tract. Upon its safe deliverance to the gut, the snake eased himself into the rafters from whence he came. At last, sleep was attainable!

Number 367 loudly exhaled for the first time in what surely must have been an hour. She'd been patiently working on the final draft of her letter to the outside world, begging anyone who could read to come help, when she'd heard a struggle in the cubicle adjacent. Any time the snake came around, a victim's best bet was to dive beneath the heaps of discarded paper in every corner, insulating their heat signature in a mound of slowly composting text. It was easy to lose a valuable document in the mess of it all, and Number 367 had started and restarted her simple project a dozen times. Each run was little more spectacular than the previous, but her progression demonstrated that elusive spark which made her unique in a sea of entropic repetition.

On a nondescript patch of Midwestern prairie exists this rapturous room, where a multitude of monkeys once churned out a chaotic crowd-sourced poem on a never-ending array of typewriters, poised to prove the ultimate futility of human creativity. The standard models had 47 keys, and since monkeys were deemed to hit them with perfect randomness, it took a while to get anything of value. The Mission Statement was a bastardization of the law of large numbers: even if the chance of typing BANANA is roughly one in 15 billion, that's almost as many opportunities to type something better. But unlimited was a lot of monkeys, so in the program's first 6 months of operation they'd already turned out some decent material, with ample typos. The odds of producing a Publishable Random Construct (PRC) increased handily if attentive humans could copy edit the imperfections. Of course, those workers not versed in the literary tradition would mistake the occasional duplicate of *The Garden* or another anthropogenic piece as fresh – such hiccups created major obstacles to productivity.

Number 367, known only to herself as Brian, arose from the cascading sheets. She wasted no time inspecting the aftermath of her neighbor's disappearance, for he was neither kin nor a friend. For the last five years a sectarian blight hung over the derelict facility and even

Brian was not immune to the disillusioned consensus. The test subjects had broken into factions when food stopped appearing at sunrise, forced into troupes of barbaric and self-serving beasts. In the beginning the mobs were large and welcoming to outsiders, but as their ranks swelled, fierce competition became a more viable survival strategy than mutualistic altruism. Scrounging for scraps yielded little, and the once tight-knit community of typists quickly began exploring a high protein diet of their unfortunate neighbors. Opportunism rewarded the violent, and the Bone Heap at Mile Two seemed to grow like a carcinoma. Brian's own tribe was built on generations of matrilineal structure, a hierarchy set in place well before the mass abductions displaced countless millions of her species. A few dozen monkeys with nothing in common but a bit of heredity and similarly cramped conditions of confinement formed a single-family unit indistinguishable from any of the others. The macaques only typed because they believed they were born to type, but for what reason, they knew not. Brian's family members sought no outcome save the return of the food they'd been promised so long ago, and made no attempts to better their state beyond taking a disproportionate fondness for the letter "S".

There is a rule in biology that states all rules tend to have exceptions. There are no absolutes, and the unexpected should be expected. Only Number 367 didn't bother with the ruckus of warfare, and instead sat at her desk, far from the action. She was as special as the pristine typewriter in front of her, a monkey who could read and write in Simple English. She called herself Brian, after the handler who had inadvertently educated her daily in human communication. A man whose awareness of macaque metacognition and self-agency was demonstrably well ahead of his time, Brian's name itself came to represent to her all that was good and unique about the higher-order ape. Of course, all this meant nothing to her cellmates, who were oblivious to the implications of these discoveries. Creeping back to her machine, she

resumed her letter to the hairless things on the outside, to bring some food or let her comrades out of this pit. The keys clacked away awkward phrasings with strange grammar, but it was by no means random.

YOU Brian HeLP mE BRIAN get out need HELP.?

Brian stopped. This couldn't be right. It didn't look a thing like the text the handlers would keep, their murmuring rapid and eyes aglow with glee. She hit the return key twice and tore the snippet of text from the machine in frustration. Nobody was ever going to see this letter, let alone read it, so why produce a text with no audience? The ever-present howling in the distance had intensified, and some other horrible monster had probably plopped itself onto the warehouse floor, hankering for dinner. Of course the tribes would try to kill it, and they would fight over the meat and the skin and the fangs and whatever else was tasty or useful, if they ever succeeded. Then they would fight over bodies of the dead. And so on, animals lived like animals.

Although frustrated with her own writers' block, Brian did not realize her shortcomings were representative of a much wider trend. The number of PRCs per subject per week had steadily declined to an all-time minimum as more unserviced machines succumbed to the elements. Of course, this value was usually a decimal many orders of magnitude smaller than one, but the graphs were showing a rapid descent towards complete statistical insignificance. Trained from birth to use typewriters, the monkeys never really stopped their work, yet without the positive reinforcement of the handlers, the keyboards functioned mostly as cathartic punching bags. Heaps of nonsensical writing lay scattered in every available space, and many discarded stacks were repurposed as nest bedding. Among these lay Shakespeare's finest unrealized meters, untested studies on wind currents and quantum superpositioning, and an

emphatic love letter addressed to one “Sally Hemmingz.” And no thought went into any of it; so why couldn’t Brian the thinker do better, make a masterpiece of her own?

Brian had been on a fast track out of the program after demonstrating her atypical intellect to the humans, and her graduation was only cut short by their sudden disappearance. Adjacent to the Type Ward’s far southern end were the Cat Room and the Bat Room, and likely a handful of other facilities where exceptional monkeys could serve out their usefulness to national security. That much she comprehended, and she’d thrown much less poop in hopes of elevating her social status, but her diligence was all for naught. Without prior notice the Type Ward’s thick iron warehouse doors were bolted down and welded shut during a marathon double-shift. The humans were out on lunch break, but they never returned, even at shift change. Brian refused to shirk her dutiful gifts in the absence of reward, because the work of creation was itself intrinsically rewarding. Yet, her efforts did little to subdue the frustration that accompanied the two hallmarks of her life in conflict: the desire and awareness to express oneself, and the inability to do so meaningfully. The quixotic and incessant explosions of cats and bats next door registered only as humble pops in the unattainable yonder, more failed experiments strangled by the constraints of fiscal responsibility.

As the distant whooping faded, Brian regretted throwing out the failed letter draft. The faint troupe was apparently full of cowards, and the standoff ended, like all the others, in a stalemate. Her writing seemed to suffer from the same fearful weakness, and never progressed in complexity. Brian felt her anxiety mounting as she tore through piles of dirty paper, looking for the trivial scrap she knew she’d spent far too long on. Her isolated cubical was evidently no longer beyond the snake’s striking range and the typewriter – the only flawless one she’d seen – was far too heavy to lug to safety on her own. Brian’s frantic rummaging ceased only when a

sharp sting radiated from her finger, because paper cuts were very unusual. In her bleeding hand was a shiny laminate document, caked with muddy residue. The words FIRE SAFETY EVACUATION PROTOCOL were visible through the dust on the fallen, factory-printed sign.

Brian blinked twice and stared at the plasticized map. Scraping at the surface with her calloused hand revealed the six-mile Type Ward with markings indicating points of interest. None of the map's locations seemed to match with the landscape as Brian knew it, but a handful of little red boxes appeared to say EXIT. She chuckled – these emergency exits were clearly made to accommodate the humans and not the macaques, uniquely positioned at research observation posts. Most if not all of these would be locked and inaccessible or sealed by weathering. Still, it was a more promising resource for escape than the holes dotting the ceiling like the aftermath of buckshot. Such was the nature of competition that the monkeys would never see their numbers as advantageous for collaborative efforts. They remained unaware of desks' stackable shapes, of the potential to construct durable stairs to salvation, embracing neophobia, the sly eye, and the craned neck. And always, two lidless eyes hungrily watched and waited from inside the refuse. Most monkeys had at least enough sense to sleep in groups – those who didn't would vanish by morning. Brian sometimes pondered the value of journaling the mundane recurrences in her life, trials and tragedies like these, but in her mind they read like factual news articles, devoid of the emotion that made anything worth reading.

As per usual, Brian was the last monkey to return to her clan's territory, and her allies were slumbering humbly in huddled rows, having dozed off during evening ritual grooming. No obvious place remained open for her to take a seat, and she was content to bury herself in the warmth of an orange, wheeled bin labeled "Rejected Situation Comedy Scripts." Brian liked to read before going to sleep, even if it kept her up later than was wise. Absorbing new ideas, even

the nonfactual or nonsensical, gave her the material with which she would weave her dreams. She tucked the fire safety document under her back and cracked open a packet of unfunny dialogue. The glaring disconnects and non-sequiturs betrayed the random origin of the plots, and the characters were forced to simply talk at one another fruitlessly. A few missed punchlines later, Brian too gave in to sleep. Two-dozen feet above, a curious nighthawk chirped.

Between Miles Three and Four rested a sizable body of water. Rainwater had seeped through holes and cracks in the roof, bleeding into a saggy stretch of mire where it coalesced and stagnated as the primary drinking source for the macaques. Here they came to bathe and imbibe in the same hole, and the space itself was a greater point of contention than the resources it held. Swathes of black mold extended hyphae across the dank tiles and eagerly lapped up the filthy fluid, but the drinkers paid it no attention. Gelatinous algae mats lazily floated in the water, patient for the coming light. At high noon on a clear day, the Sun would bear down directly through the gaps and its blazing reflection would illuminate the entire pool a hue of sickly green. From above, the Water Hole looked like a giant infected wound, slowly bowing to the will of ultimate necrosis. Today Brian was attempting to discern her reflection through the glowing ripples, but all around were howling spitting idiots, kicking up waves they'd freshly polluted. The squabbling often devolved to vile wrestling matches, delineating a clear winner and loser. She picked up a broken hammer with a tiny L on the head, and dragged it through the unsightly fungus. Grey tile seemed to gasp for air as the mold tore and gave way to the metal. With a dozen or so long strokes, Brian carved "HeLP" into the ground, and walked off, forgetting about her image in the waves. Calligraphy was not part of the curriculum.

Brian's clan inhabited a chunk of floor space within reasonable walking distance of the Water Hole, but other macaques lined up along her path home, baring their teeth and pining for

the miniscule misstep that would be grounds for physical confrontation. All too often Brian had been scratched at and beaten on this trek, and the sea of vacuous eyes following her promised a return trip no different from the one she'd grown so accustomed to. The monkeys threw strange offerings to Brian, proposing trades in exchange for sex. Ever since the handlers had taught the subjects the concept of monetary value, Brian's male co-workers relentlessly badgered females into making trades for putrid meat, shiny rocks, or more asinine things, like poetry and prose. The trick was to avoid any eye contact that might mislead a suitor into taking what he already believed was his. Brian kept her eyes on the mildew gradient, which faded away to dirt as she left the dank and warped bowl of grey-green soup. Bitter militant jeers eventually grew distant and Brian glanced up to find herself back at the clan's camp sooner than she'd expected.

Brian fished out the evacuation laminate from her bin and stared at it again, as if begging it to unfold into a real door out of hell. Inside the Type Ward there was no prospect for the spark of inspiration that could drive Brian or her unwritten plot forward. She'd already attempted plagiarizing, adapting, and even learning from the limitless library of PRCs abandoned in orange, wheeled bins, but all her efforts only begot more text that seemed equally "random." Every time she thought a new opus was upon her, she discovered somebody else had already produced it. Indeed came the dread: it had all been said. The end was dead. The exercise of writing felt increasingly pointless, with no audience, no innovation, and thus, no way to differentiate herself from the infinite monkeys. Maybe she was not so special after all, Brian thought.

All troupes observed an unwavering hierarchy, and the Alphas insisted any and all important discoveries be brought before them for a verdict on the bounty's distribution. Usually these "discoveries" amounted to little more than fresh carcasses or corroded junk, yet the whole ordeal was ritualized, and weighted in the Alphas' favor. Brian had worked up the courage to

seek their attention only once before, when she'd completed her first story nearly a year before. With a prideful spring in her bound, she'd presented *Chair Man Moo's Little Red Brick* to the couple, hoping for some validation. They could not read it, however, and believing her writing to be another nonsensical forgery, confiscated the packet to "use as bedding." Brian had not expected her education to surpass that of the Alphas governing her. Brian's plastic map reflected dim shafts of sunlight as she approached the couple's nest, trying to appear confident. She was now certain neither they nor the rest of her tribe could read a single word. The Alphas were seated facing the wall, allowing weaker macaques to pick through their hair and eat the insects and parasites. Brian took a seat silently on the open floor space between two massive shelves.

"Who is there behind us?" The Alpha male hollered to his groomer, who glanced back.

"It is that typer who thinks she can make *meaning* from the machines!"

"That typer, you say?" The Alpha male turned and walked up to Brian, halting only when she could feel his hot breath exiting through his nose. A bushel of piercings, crafted from bone fragments and typewriter hammers, jingled from each ear. "To what do you owe our pleasure today?" A narcissist's way of saying, this had better be good. The female watched from behind.

"Alpha, I think I found something important. It's a sheet – a special sheet. I think it can tell us how to get out of this place forever." Brian watched his eyes as they flicked across a body of text she knew would be meaningless to him, and she could see the skepticism welling up. The Alpha male erupted with hoots of laughter, passing the map to his mate. She too was amused.

"But it is only squares!" The Alpha female brandished the laminate to the groomers.

"Squares and nonsense like all the sheets, this is nothing special!" She spun to face Brian, glaring caustically. "And you bring these squares of nothing to *us*, talking of *how to get out*."

"There is no out, there is only in. Yes, here is all that is," the Alpha male said.

“Here is all that is,” his mate parroted over his shoulder.

“Those squares, that is a picture of this place, here,” Brian was struggling to remain patient. “This,” she said, pointing at the header, “says it shows where the exits are.”

“Silence!” The Alpha male exploded, causing his entire court to flinch. “No, none can read it because there is nothing to read. The typer lies to us, to bring about our deaths!” The groomers started towards Brian dutifully and she backed up a step, waving and protesting her detention. They bore no sympathetic gaze as they slowly descended upon her.

“Here cannot be all there is; there must be more!” Her voice cracked pitifully. “What of the serpent? The serpent! Where did he come from?” The groomers each seized one of her arms, reorienting Brian to face the Alphas under restraint. She was panting and tugging at her bondage.

“It is true,” the Alpha male conceded, “that foul thing is not from here. It is from somewhere else. But this ‘somewhere else,’ why go there? How can the void from whence that serpent came be superior to the home we know and have always known? No, you must not *get out*. If you open the doors, if they see you, more will come. Yes, more will come here and they will destroy us. You will destroy us!” He pounded his fist on a desk.

“I can read and I can prove it!” Brian heard herself yelping the phrase.

“If that were true, you would be even more dangerous than you already are.” Brian felt a sharp pain in the back of her head and then nothing but muddy blackness.

A mile and a half north of the Water Hole, a giant midden rose up, obscuring the last stretches of the Type Ward behind it. The Bone Pile was the designated resting place for all cleaned carcass waste, but ample killing nourished the mound, and it had grown so large it blocked all passage around on stable flooring. Wall-to-wall, meters-thick mosaics of crushed skulls, fractured femurs, snapped spines, and pulverized pelvises nearly grazed the ceiling in

some spots. The outer surface was peppered with bioluminescent mushrooms whose hyphae were feasting on the composting mess within the Bone Pile, and the structure cast a chalky, bluish glow on the immediate vicinity. Skeletal dunes extended into the black yonder, past the braver macaques' line of sight. Nobody went past it; the Alphas maintained that it most likely extended north, petering out at the far northern wall. Executions were performed at the Bone Pile so the dead could be stripped of their meat and discarded where they lay.

Brian slowly opened her eyes, wincing as her cranium throbbed. She lay in a wide pool of coagulated blood that was not her own, caked and flaking. Silverfish of varying sizes nibbled at the layer of spilled flesh, and Brian tried to look away. Her temples stung as her vision refocused on a monkey skull a few feet before her. A mushroom was protruding from the eye socket and the lower jaw was absent. Everyone waking up in this spot meets the same grisly fate. Brian tried to keep up her façade of unconsciousness long enough to establish her surroundings and size up the enemy. Through thin slits of sight she saw the two groomers heaving one of the bulky grey typewriters up to the spot. Brian was surprised to hear a deep voice she could not locate.

"Are you familiar with altruism, typer?" The hairs on Brian's neck stood up. "Sacrificing one's gain for the good of the group?" She groaned and arched her back in a long stretch, gathering herself to a sitting position. "It's a duty all of us are bound to, some more than others." On the last word a heavy foot kicked Brian forward onto the floor.

"I could have saved all of you," Brian rasped. "There's still a chance, with that map."

"The map is staying here with you. And so is this 'story,' the one that first got you into all this nonsense." A fistful of papers fluttered before Brian's face and she felt her stomach drop. *Little Red Brick* was the only thing she'd written that she'd been happy with, and she'd assumed it was long gone, fermenting under the filthy calloused buttocks of the Alphas. Yet, here it was,

apparently along with her exit map. “Groomers, come! Typer, normally we would just rip you to ribbons, but given the special circumstances of your dissent, we came up with something a bit more... targeted. So long as these two do not miss their mark.” The groomers positioned themselves over her, only a few fingers suspending the typewriter directly over Brian’s head. “And since you love these silly words so much it seems only fitting you should say something. You know, before we kill and skin you.” Brian spat on the ground and again forced herself to turn over and face the Alpha male’s crude dangling death device.

“I hope the snake gets you.” The groomers roared with laughter, nearly dropping the typewriter prematurely. “That’s all I’ve got to say to you.”

“Well now, there is a better idea,” the Alpha male countered. “Since you enjoy the snake so much, you should be free to live with him! If he’s interested, of course. What’s say we, eh, give her these worthless words back, and see how they fare against the snake? No matter who kills the other, it is one less problem for us.” The groomers lobbed the typewriter to the side, and it landed with the metallic screams of its warping components, uncomfortably close to Brian’s head. They grabbed Brian’s shoulders and hoisted her to a standing position. Handing her the packet of *Little Red Brick* and the exit laminate, the Alpha male gestured toward the abyss. “Your home is there now. To quote your famous last words, ‘I hope the snake gets you.’”

Brian fumbled through the darkness beyond the highest peaks of the Bone Pile, tripping and slipping on avalanches of femurs, with only the faint fungi to guide her. She plucked a plump toadstool from near her feet and held it up, illuminating her map. She was just past Mile Five, and there was supposed to be a nearby utility stairwell with fire escape, mere hundreds of feet away. On her inky horizon Brian could make out a dimly glowing edifice, and she began to

lumber toward the light. Her ribs ached from the feet of her captors, and she quietly flailed her arms before her to identify any unseen obstacles.

The stairwell was past its optimum state; mosses and fungi hugged the steel girders, tirelessly attempting to subjugate a stronger opponent. Some steps had rusted through, and the handrail was nowhere to be seen. It didn't stand out much amongst the rubble of failure, the dust and decay of the Type Ward. Except one of the posts was moving.

Brian locked eyes with the pair of golden serpentine slits hovering in midair. She froze, biting her lip and holding her breath as she stood a foot from Houdini's pliable maw. The snake stared blank, waiting for a motion cue. Brian glanced to her left; she would probably give away her position before that thing would lose interest. It could smell her, just by tasting the air. The only nearby object Brian could see was a broken typewriter that had been thrown from the observation post above the stairwell. The carriage was detached and lay beside the wreckage. It was out of reach, and she would need to execute the first movement to retrieve it.

She heard a hiss, but Brian had tunnel vision and saw only the carriage as her fingers closed around one end, like a club. Houdini was upon her before she could react, striking with the force and swiftness of a professional boxer. *CLANG!* The serpent recoiled, dazed and disoriented. The monkey, in power stance, had blocked her foe's bite with the metal carriage, but Houdini rebounded and struck again, this time at the neck. Brian held out the carriage, catching and propping the snake's mouth wide open. She backed away as the furious predator writhed and sputtered, working its four independently attached jawbones against the iron. Brian made for the stairs, taking the steps two or three at a time. Houdini lacerated his mouth on the carriage and regurgitated it with blood and bile. He angrily swept it aside with his massive tail, redirecting his

focus on the fleeing macaque. Twisting ventral scales lifted and dropped in rapid undulation as eight feet of muscle contorted, propelling death forward.

Brian wasn't looking back, and for once her thoughts were not revolving around the endless permutations of English language, but on basic, raw survival instinct. She galloped on all fours, scaling the steps to the observation platform in record monkey time. The researchers had made no attempts to encourage physical exercise for the test subjects, and Brian had never felt stronger. Even up in the humans' ivory tower were countless rejected writing samples. The damp mush of decaying words squelched beneath her feet, overwhelming her trail with the stench of decomposing starch and bleach. Houdini flicked his tongue as he maneuvered up the stairwell, noting the chemical signal his target was dragging behind her.

I am going to eat, Houdini thought. His mesolimbic reward pathway had uttered one simple phrase, food, and this basal need was now everything. This prey was a challenge the others hadn't yet presented, an unprecedented obstacle he could not ignore. At any rate, this was likely to be the only edible monkey in the nearest mile. Better to flank it from above.

Brian ran along the high scaffolding against the wall, looking for the exit hallway door. Twice something brushed her leg, and she seized up with the anticipation of defeat. At the far end, Brian stood hunched, scoping back for indications of the snake. Seeing nothing, she continued, at a slow relieving trot. Looming behind was the Bone Heap; only a few feet separated the roof from the summit, and the slopes eclipsed the entire Type Ward. The catwalk halted abruptly, and Brian smacked her forehead. She had actually ran past the exit door, who knows how far back. She reversed, no more than a hundred feet before the orange rusty hinges caught her eye. Freedom sat mere inches away, beyond this forgotten door. She grabbed the handle and tugged it. Then a very sharp pain hit Brian's leg.

Houdini was delighted to find his fangs sinking into a piece of animal muscle they truly deserved. The prey was shrieking and twisting, pulling at the door, which did make it difficult to wrap around and choke, but a challenge is always better than a cakewalk.

Brian thought of her family, the flea-bitten group of pink monkeys festering in their futile body of work every day. She thought of Houdini's insatiable hunger for flesh and fear, and how many relatives and friends of hers had been lifted out of the abyss, never to return. And she thought of words, of how none of her learning could save her from imminent destruction. Foremost on her mind, however, were the fangs imbedded in her thigh. Houdini pulsed his musculature from the head downward, tightening his tail's grip and pushing Brian against the door. Her face pressed against the cold steel and Brian thought she could see the end to her life. She pushed with her legs against the door handle, seeking the leverage to break loose.

Unbeknownst to snake or monkey, the poor lighting had blocked off a very important detail about the safety door. One word: Push. The combined weight of the wrestling animals threw the exit ajar, and they tumbled into the gaping hall. Houdini lost his grip, and Brian yelped as his teeth left her body. The door to the outside lay a few paces forward, and Brian's breathing was growing heavier with each lunge. She realized the manuscript of *Little Red Brick* was still within her clutches. With pangs of desperation she whipped the precious packet to the left, her peripherals catching the waltz of falling sheets. Houdini struck at the sheets, which had absorbed Brian's body heat as she'd tightly held them. She was at the door, and she couldn't look. Brian shoved the handles downward and pushed out. The exit gave easily and she dove through the crack, trying to slam it behind her. Houdini's face was snapping at her fingers from the other side. He paused and recoiled, preparing for a more accurate strike. Brian moved with him, slamming the mighty door as his head came flying through the gap. A sickening crack left the

predator twitching like a salted leech on the ground, his spinal cord severed. His eyes spun wildly in their sockets like amber billiard balls, before flopping on his backside and stiffening.

Brian stared down at the lifeless Burmese python, and instantly regretted killing it. She'd wanted to lock it in with those degenerates who'd cast her out like refuse. Sighing, Brian made sure Houdini's carcass propped the door open enough to encourage further incursions. Then, she realized, she'd made it out! She whirled around and her jaw dropped. Beyond a jungle of barbed wire and other security measures, a highway was visible. Cars were driving on it, right past the perimeter of the compound, and had likely been doing so Brian's entire life. A fading green sign above an entrance read: ARPA MIDWEST RESEARCH COMPLEX: PROPERTY OF U.S. GOVERNMENT. Brian couldn't believe what she was seeing – the humans left, and *nobody* did anything to take care of the monkeys, or bothered to come back?

In fact, America didn't care about the monkeys' well being because they were unpopular with the public. A desperate ARPA figured the monkeys would perform better with the option to take breaks and roam freely, but the Old World primates abused their privileges and just threw feces most of the time. A sizable organic brain can run the equivalent of several megaflops (millions of floating point observations per second) but most of these calculations are reserved for maintaining internal biochemical homeostasis, leaving little to the imagination. When members of Congress toured the facility, they brought back to Washington embarrassing budgetary figures and a handful of mediocre writing samples. The commission found "gross mismanagement of government funds," and recommended immediate termination. "And furthermore," the report notes, "Everybody damn well knows monkeys cannot write. This is stupid."

Quit and Win

Oct. 17

Have decided to try and quit smoking cigarettes. Joined Campus Quit and Win today and the lady said doing a journal could help keep track of cravings, success, failure, etc. Not big into this kinda stuff so I'll keep it short and sweet. Considered quitting cigs a lot recently for several reasons and the lady told me to start by listing them:

1. Girlfriend says she's sick of me smelling like a landscaper. I say this isn't fair because I am a landscaper and we smoke to pass time because work is boring. She smokes too but says my half a pack per day is too much. I think she's right about that and it eats up my paychecks. Would rather buy her something nice with the \$\$\$ I save. Wish she would quit with me but she says I'm the one with the addiction problem, the one who tries to get her permission to smoke inside when the weather makes me too lazy to step out.
2. Was late to class yesterday and almost puked up a lung. I'm often late and I think I'm getting asthma. Stairs are too hard now and make me wheeze and cough but I never notice until I'm late and have to run instead of waiting in line for elevator. Bad sign for a 22-year-old. Not fun to show up late and also very sweaty. Classmates stare at my drippy forehead and give me funny looks. Somebody always asks, "Is something burning?"
3. Botany professor threatened to kick me out of his lab class if I show up reeking like smoke one more time. Biggest reason for me the student because I need his class to graduate. Prof told us on first day the smokers had to wash their hands before entering greenhouse. Said cigs are full of tobacco mosaic virus and it infects almost anything like potatoes and tomatoes too even after you smoke them to the filter. Asked him why the tobacco companies would knowingly sell a product full of a disease. Prof looked at me like I was insane or stupid or both but didn't answer my question. Long story short I

didn't buy his story and didn't wash my hands. A week later my group found our heirloom tomatoes wilted and mottled. Necrotic lesions with chlorotic borders. Copied those terms from my notes, but it means I killed our project. Group didn't have to rat on me cause Prof knew. Turns out tomatoes are very close cousin of tobacco. Who knew? Didn't do so hot in school last semester, got to do well to prove my parents wrong, I'm not lazy, just wasn't being motivated properly. If I get kicked out of lab I fail the class.

Want to keep girlfriend, finish school, and not end up puffing cigs through metal trach hole. All very important things to me. Also the lady told me Campus Quit and Win actually lets you enter special challenges and raffles win shit, not just "win" your good health back like some lame scam. Xbox and Playstation shit, tickets to South Padre Spring Break Extravaganza shit, one year of free Chipotle shit. Shit worth quitting for. I figure I can just sit and smile through the bull and get free swag out of the deal. If I actually quit that'd be cool too. I don't even want a cigarette right now. This should be easy as hell.

Oct. 18

Relapsed already. Couldn't even make it past 9 AM and needed cigarette. Confusing because I know they are bad but I feel kinda sick if I don't have one by a certain point. Lady said this would happen and important thing is be honest with myself and get back on the old wagon to try again. Recognize patterns and find out my triggers for smoking. Probably my girlfriend's fault. She smoked one and offered me one too even though she wants me to quit. Took it of course and forgot about Campus Quit and Win till halfway through. Tried to drop cig in defiance and ended up picking it off ground to finish it like some homeless guy. Might need some more help quitting. Emailed botany lab group (Cc'd Prof) to tell them I was trying my best and to beg for forgiveness. Washed hands, stopped by greenhouse. Our tomatoes are still dead and refuse to let

the whole thing go. Prof put them in a big clear bag labeled BIOHAZARD and sent them to incinerator so rest of class wouldn't get virus. A bigger deal than I realized, apparently. Going to wash hands more now even if not smoking. Wondering if virus is hiding inside my body somewhere. Can I ever garden in the future, or am I destined to be just a big bag of crop disease? Called doctors at Penn State University Health and explained my situation to them. They said they can help me as early as tomorrow. This made me anxious and excited and I stole a cigarette from girlfriend while she was in shower. Deserved it for taking right steps.

Oct. 19

Not normally required to journal every day (weekly is minimum) but enjoying it and things keep happening quickly. This morning wanted cigarette but had change of heart when I saw girlfriend's houseplants. She keeps them on bedroom windowsill and they leave nice minty smells and shit on our hands if we touch them. Sure enough they had a rippling mosaic pattern on them and they weren't dead but maybe a bit wilted. Felt too guilty to smoke because sick houseplants are probably my fault. Made a cup of black coffee instead which usually goes well with cigarette but also goes well with cold rainy days and guilt for people like me. Looked up tobacco mosaic virus on my phone, found out we lost the battle against it and farmers have to harvest the sick plants if they even want to profit. Doctor's appointment was great on other hand and he gave me an easy way out of this whole mess. Imagine a medicine that makes you just not want or need to smoke – what a time to be alive! He says it blocks the nicotine receptors in my brain so that even if I try, smoking won't relieve my craving and I'll eventually stop associating cigs with pleasure. Of this final claim I am skeptical but I'm not the doctor and I agreed to try his medicine. He said it's called Chantix, and that it's got a great track record with making smokers hate smoking. All I have to do is take it once a day, every day.

Oct. 20

Made amends to lab group. They actually seem cooler about it now it's blown over and done with. We were lucky and he didn't take off any points this time. Prof still told me it better not happen again and if it did he would blame me first, which is bullshit but what can I do? Note to self: get girlfriend to bake cookies so I can thank them for patience w/ me. Gotta build rapport.

Oct. 23

It's a miracle! I've been taking this pill every day for a week and I literally never think about smoking or how badly I want to smoke. I've been so busy not thinking about smoking that I almost forgot this success was worth putting in my journal and I haven't written in a few days. Girlfriend says she's proud of my willpower cause I didn't tell her about the Chantix. Nicotine receptors be damned, I'm going to prove everybody who said I couldn't quit wrong. Maybe once I quit I can convince girlfriend to quit. It is truly a nasty habit to fall into. Had first Campus Quit and Win group meeting today and kicked some ass. Sat in circles with some "students like me," which couldn't have been farther from the truth. Reminded me of those AA meetings you see in movies, but a bit more lively and no nonsense about Steps or Staying Clean. Same old sob stories mostly: significant others and/or landlords are tired of stale cig odors, grandma/grandpa/Uncle Pat died of emphysema and don't wanna repeat history, too broke to smoke both cigs and cannabis and had to pick the better one. Ya know, the difficult stuff. I like to think my story was more interesting, but in weird way felt like classic rock-bottom moment. In face of ultimatum one man must make Earth-shattering decision of unparalleled moral and psychological gravity. Finds Jesus or Zoroaster as a perk of the journey. One chick said her ex liked to put out his cigs on her back while they had sex but she liked the burn and I will be sitting in a different small circle group next week so I never have to hear of this again. Ginger dude with dreds is nice

enough, but said he's smoked since he was 12. Not to judge but where the fuck were his parents? Guy in leather jacket with spikes had a t-shirt with a no-smoking logo that said, "there are cooler ways to die," but I don't think he's found even one yet. Came home and for first time noticed girlfriend smelled weirdly like a landscaper. Now I understand why she didn't like all that smoke on my clothes. Didn't want to be a hypocrite and kept my mouth shut.

Oct. 24

Woke up feeling funny. Had the odd sense that a lot of... stuff happened while I was out, but it's bizarre because I can't really remember any of my dreams from last night. Have a vague hunch they were bad dreams cause the funny was unpleasant. Probably the nicotine withdrawals. Brushed it off and enjoyed my morning coffee. It's become something of a replacement routine addiction for me, but I reckon that's okay cause coffee doesn't give people cancer or eat my homework. Wouldn't mind a cigarette...? Prof can't believe how quickly I stopped smoking and actually forgave me (in person) for the whole tobacco mosaic thing. Very glad that scandal is behind me now. Group still asks me to wash hands before entering greenhouse and I humor their worries. It's ironic cause we're on a plant pathology unit, actually learning now about the shit that kills important crops. Fungi and bacteria and viruses and other tiny things we need microscopes to see. Instead of just growing plants we're trying to kill them for a grade and I was definitely good at that. In front of me today were half a dozen beautiful tomato plants, each nearly as tall as me. These are what our last project should have ended up like. Had to stab all their stems and rub their small wounds with a strange goo. It stank like body odor and looked slimy like pus. Prof wouldn't tell us what it was (in suspense till next week) but said we were explicitly forbidden (his words) from taking it or our plants beyond the walls of the classroom. How tantalizing! I'm just excited that I might not have to waste my New Year's resolution

getting the cig monkey off my back. Girlfriend said she's proud of me too. Then she went and smoked a cigarette without me outside. She should probably consider quitting. It'd do her good.

Oct. 25

Had a weird thing happen today coming home from class. Walked past Indigo Coffee on Main and could've sworn I saw girlfriend in there talking and laughing with some guy. Locked eyes even, I think she looked surprised. Didn't look too long cause she said she was working this afternoon. Not her. Couldn't be. That's crazy. But it looked just like her. Mentioned it to her later, she gave me a funny look, and just said, "but I was at work. I don't even like Indigo, it's always so fucking loud, playing that smooth radio shit." I could've sworn I saw a lie in her eyes and I don't know if I really did see her at Indigo but it had to be her. Think I need more sleep because this mystery doesn't look like it's gunna solve itself.

Oct. 26

Got in first big argument with girlfriend today. Been together almost a whole year so this is a big deal, especially to her. Said she was gunna go grab Panera with a few of her sorority sisters, I asked her if she was sure she wasn't going to Indigo. I meant it as a joke but she got really defensive and it was definitely weird. She yelled at me and said I've been judging her for smoking cigs now and I'm a hypocrite and mean and controlling and yada yada yada. Something is up with girlfriend and she's getting really bad at hiding it. Don't know how it took me this long to notice this stuff, it's clearly always been a problem. On plus-side unrelated note: got first lab report back from Prof. Never woulda guessed: I got a solid A on the work!

Oct. 27

Not sure what to do. It is 3:30 AM and just woke up sweating with a sinking feeling. Girlfriend is cheating on me. I know it – can feel it – not really sure how I know it's true but these are the

gut feelings you don't ignore. I should have been suspicious when I saw her texting my dad last night. Said she was texting her friend Sarah but I saw the phone and it definitely said dad. Thought at first maybe they were planning my birthday present. At the time thought I was imagining that little red heart icon but now in retrospect should have known something weird was up. Actually feel angrier at dad for flirting with girlfriend – always had a hunch he was dirty old man but this confirms it, and why did it have to be my girlfriend? She's said she's into men a bit older than her, which is why I thought she liked me, but this is just ridiculous. My girlfriend is cheating on me with my fucking father. Nobody's gonna believe me and mom will definitely think I'm nuts. How to confront girlfriend, I have no clue. So disgusted I can't even lay down next to her and I am on couch typing this. Thinking back to moments that might've tipped me off. Met my parents for first time last year and said she loved them. Said my dad was super funny. Girls like funny guys. I look a lot like my dad and I wonder if she's only with me cause of the uncanny resemblance. Maybe he's more distinguished in appearance than I am. Parents asked for her number in case of emergency – no wait, dad asked for her number. Or was it mom? Want a cig real bad for some reason and I think I need to take my Chantix early today – first real craving since I started and I'm real worried about that. Going back to bed for a few hours. I've been sleeping less heavily lately – must be the nicotine withdrawals.

Back again. Sleep was unsatisfying. Need more evidence to expose girlfriend, I think. Acted normal as best as I could and went to class. Tried not to think about her and my dad, but fairly sure I heard her whispering to him while I was dozing off. Maybe sending him a text with a voice message in it while she thinks I'm asleep. She sounded excited about something, but not like she was getting free ice cream – it was more sultry and pleasantly taken aback, like when we're drunk and I whisper in her ear what I'd like to do to her. Girlfriend did say I kept waking

her up last night with my loud sleep mumbling but that sounds suspicious to me cause I've never done anything like that before. She got up to pee and I stole a glance at her phone. No texts to or from my dad, so she must've deleted them to cover her tracks. I'll have to keep my eye on it.

Oct 29

Had to walk past Indigo Coffee today. Wasn't on my way home this time. Don't know why I did it and can't decide whether I'm glad I did or furious about it. I got a better look at the girl there and it has to be girlfriend so she is lying to me about how she spends her free time. Worse, the guy wasn't some young, built dude but lo and behold, my fucking father. Drove four hours to get here, the freak. I had to duck so they wouldn't see my look of horror and recognize my awareness of the affair. If girlfriend wasn't 19 I would've already called the police about this. How to ask her about my dad without giving it all away? Meeting might teach me strategies.

Oct 30

Second meeting today, wasn't stoked to go, went anyway cause to get free shit I can't miss any meetings. They say they just "wanna check in on how our progress is coming," but they don't have a crazy girlfriend to worry about and watch over. They can go do things without worrying about their girlfriend sleeping with their dad and I don't have that luxury. Blackburn girl wasn't there this week though. Probably pulling a fast one on her man, like my girlfriend. She can't get any free shit now, might as well not come back to the other meetings. Good riddance. The lady is getting annoying and keeps handing out pamphlets for "sober events" but I don't have time to waste if I'm going to expose this whole thing wide open.

Oct 31

Just getting out of the ER, and am officially no longer prescribed Chantix. Girlfriend and docs saw to it after last night. She was concerned I was acting weird all day but it got bad when we

turned in to sleep. I awoke to a soaking bed and my girlfriend standing over me, pouring gallons of gasoline. Dad was there too, handing her fresh jugs whenever she depleted one. They lit me on fire and embraced tightly, kissing one another and cackling gleefully as the flames devoured my body and bedsheets. Somehow I woke up again. Girlfriend was still standing over me. Slapping me. No gas. No dad. I was sobbing uncontrollably and I saw some holes in the wall directly to my left. My knuckles were bleeding and swollen. She screaming wake up and me screaming about whores and bitches and fire and death and destruction. It was like I picked up a rant midsentence and just ran with it, not thinking. The sheets were soaked with my sweat and tears, and girlfriend was yelling stop stop stop and trying to hit me. Tried to hold her back and pretty sure I hit her. She locked herself in the bathroom and called 911. She sounded as angry and confused as I did, but she was the one conspiring against me with my father, so at the time it seemed unreasonable. I remember two cops and several paramedics attempting to drag me out of my flat, more yelling, a sharp prick, then nothing. A flashlight hit me in the eyes and stung me back awake, and they wanted to know what drugs I took. I don't take drugs, I told them repeatedly. What medications are you on? None! Are you a smoker? Not anymore, thanks to Chantix. But my crazy girlfriend is fucking it all up for me. The worst part, I sobbed, was that in return for it all, all my sacrifices and hard work, she was seeing my fucking father behind my back. After force-feeding me some benzodiazepines, which calmed me down enough to stop and listen, I was asked if my physician had described the risks and side effects of nicotinic antagonist medication. Nicotine is only a drug because it is acting on a part of our brain normally reserved for other signaling. By blocking the nicotinic receptors from tobacco I was apparently also blocking their entire functionality and upsetting the balance of my brain chemistry. Unsurprisingly, the typical result in unsuccessful patients is nightmarish delusions with clear-as-

day detail, particularly during sleep. The lies the brain constructs bleed into everyday thoughts until the conscious mind cannot distinguish between reality and its own fictions. Why these fictions are so often unpleasant or persecutory is probably related to as-of-yet poorly understood functionality in the nicotinic system. Visions of betrayal, graphic death, and other horrible things are part of the fine print in using medication instead of willpower. I have a doctor's note excusing me from class today for "an adverse reaction to my prescribed medicine," and one of my nurses bummed me a cig with a look of fearful wonder in her eyes.

Nov. 5

Girlfriend is finally willing to sleep at my house with me again. Can't say I blame her. She was ridiculously understanding of the whole ordeal and assured me that coverup could do wonders for a black eye, but wanted a full week to let my brain reset itself from crazy mode. She's not happy to see that I've been up to my old tricks, smoking half a pack a day again. I'm still in Campus Quit and Win, but I've been chewing gum before meetings to keep up the lie that I give a shit about getting the monkey off my back. I am forced to choose a life where society shuns and criticizes my decisions about what I choose to put in my body, or a life defined by my brain's own sick creative nightmares. I feel I will never be able to cut my own demand for cigarettes unless I can destroy the supply entirely. Prof knows about the whole mess and personally reminds me to wash my hands every time I see him in class. He did tell us more about the foul goo from the previous week, which we discovered had browned and collapsed our once-proud tomato plants into lumps of decaying sticky mulch. It is a humble bacterium, *Ralstonia solanacearum*, and we cannot take it home with us unless we want the FBI to come knocking at our door. It can wipe out entire crops, even those that are genetically resistant, and is so unselective in its host that almost any plant we consider valuable makes suitable food for the

microbe. The government calls it a “Select Agent,” which means bioterrorists may someday seek to use it to destroy food sources and starve civilians to death. But it certainly loves tobacco, and makes the plants so sick they are totally unfit for harvest. Naturally when my group was preoccupied with a nematode under the microscope, I bagged up a section of the rotting mess and placed it in my backpack.

1. Nov. 7

I’ve started growing my own tomatoes at home, and it doesn’t matter if I wash my hands after smoking because they’re all gunna die anyway. I still have the *Ralstonia* culture bagged up, and when the seedlings grow decent shoots I will infect the plants and grow more of the pathogen.

Nov. 10

I’ve come to the rapid and unfortunately astute conclusion that the only way to make all my problems go away is to nip them at their common root. This happens to be the tobacco in my life, on which I am admittedly currently smoking. I’m driving out to the fields in Eastern PA today with a bit of a surprise. Since I cannot keep the tobacco out of my life, and every honest effort I’ve made has been pretty much for nothing, I think the only way is to destroy it. All of it. At least as much as I can so I can’t buy cigs anywhere in America anymore. This is where that *Ralstonia* shit comes in handy. All I have to do is take a Windex bottle with this shit and water in it, and spray all over the field without getting caught in the process. That will kill all the tobacco there. That’ll be a good start for today. Tomorrow I’ll drive down to Virginia and start there. By New Year’s, I’m hoping to cover the entire Eastern seaboard. Once all the tobacco is good and sick I can just grow tomatoes all day in garden. I think dedication like that will show girlfriend I’m still a standup guy.